

## Research

Forms a significant part of the product design process. This includes comparative product research and user research, to determine the ways in which products are used

## Process of product design

It's not all about creativity when it comes to product design. A lot of analytical processes take place involving research and engineering. Then comes sketching, modeling, and CAD design

Micro trends can be defined as some of changes we've seen in very well established sectors, like white goods/ consumer durables being available in all colours and designs as opposed to their earlier standard visual appeal.

"A macro trend, and this is what we're more interested in, is coming into focus because of globalisation. This puts even smaller companies on a level playing field to be able to compete with the big guys. As a result of this, designers have moved

Himanshu Mishra, Product Designer,  
CPDM, IISc, Bangalore



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up from concept design and aesthetics to something much more strategic such as innovation and understanding users in a new way." is Eskild's opinion. Defining it further Himanshu says "Specialisation, and *scope for exploration* for the user, are other trends that are emerging especially when it comes to personal devices as they allow the consumers to challenge their limits and explore beyond the established norms of usage of a device, for example multi-level connectivity on a communication device like a cell phone through social networks and network services, or features that allow enhanced quality of experience by being more capable in hardware. As far as the embodiment is concerned, there is a trend for more usable designs which are more

liked not only from a distance but during the usage, like in handling, carrying, operation and storage, to mention a few. For example, computing devices that fit snugly into pockets or are extremely light weight and small yet powerful are common."

## Collaborative Innovation

"Everyone has good ideas but what was lacking in the last century was a way for companies to harness these ideas and work collaboratively to generate solutions for tricky problems. **Innocentive.com** is a good example of providing a platform for everyone to collaborate and work on thorny issues," says Paritosh Desai – Design Planner and Strategist, alumnus of IIT Institute of Design (Illinois Institute of Technology, Chicago).

**Innocentive.com** is the first global web community for open innovation, enabling scientists, engineers, professionals and entrepreneurs to collaborate to deliver breakthrough solutions for innovative R&D-driven organisations. "I personally believe that participatory design is the way of the future. There are users in every context (whether it be in the development of jets or web sites) and their input has tremendous value in helping not only create a successful product but also inherently create strong brand loyalty. Similarly, this power could be leveraged by corporations as a means to get their consumers involved in setting direction, modifying products and in creating a strong brand loyalty." Paritosh adds.

## Crowdsourcing

In our open source special (August issue) we went in depth into crowdsourcing which is being used to develop several categories of products including green cars. But as we found, it's mostly at the concept level. "Primarily, the kind of design that is getting crowd sourced is the type in which the tools required to design are easily available, and easy



Designers at work at Cisco's design studio

to learn apart from the creativity of an individual. Hence, I believe it has affected the print and graphic design industry in a bigger way, but when it comes to cross disciplinary design like product development, I think it still has a long way to go," says Himanshu.

Being a democratic process, crowdsourcing has its pros and cons. The pros being that everyone contributes with their own ideas to a common platform, giving all those with a creative bent of mind to give the design exercise a shot. Also, the goal gets a pool of fresh ideas unaffected by the way the designers think.

"On the flip side, the major con being that there are certain peculiarities of every design exercise, however simple it may seem to an outsider, and hence the sensitivity to those crucial ingredients that go into the design might get affected when an enthusiast executes a design as opposed to a designer," says Himanshu.

To conclude, we leave you with what Paritosh told us about the imminent future. Definitely something to mull over. "In the future, the role of the designer will change. The designer's role will be to facilitate conversations, decipher insights and create seeds for products that the average user can then morph to their own needs and tastes. The designer will be a researcher, facilitator and the gardener of people's gardens of ideas." 

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